

Comments for Planning Application DM2025/01591

Application Summary

Application Number: DM2025/01591

Address: Ambulance Station Dorset Road Belmont SM2 6JH

Proposal: Change of use from Sui Generis (Ambulance Station) to mixed use Classes F1 (Places of Worship) and F2 (Community Hub) involving the erection of a part one, part two storey front and side extension, increase in height to part of building and provision of cycle and refuse stores.

Case Officer: Polly Davidson

Customer Details

Name: Mr Uzair Khalid

Address: 66 Sandy Lane Cheam SM2 7EN

Comment Details

Commenter Type:

Stance: Customer made comments in support of the Planning Application

Comment Reasons:

Comment: I support the application referenced for the below reasons:

1. Response to Reduction in Local Community Services

Residents have experienced reduced access to structured and affordable community venues due to wider pressures on public services. The proposed facility will provide a stable, long-term venue for community activity that is not dependent on fluctuating public provision. By offering additional capacity for community use, the development will complement existing civic infrastructure and help maintain continuity of local services.

2. Provision of Affordable Indoor Community Space

There is a recognised shortage of accessible and affordable indoor space suitable for community activities. The proposed development will provide flexible, bookable halls capable of accommodating:

- Youth engagement programmes
- Cultural and educational activities
- Community learning and tuition
- Health and wellbeing workshops

The availability of low-cost, multi-functional indoor space will enable a wide range of local groups to operate within the borough, supporting inclusive participation and efficient use of land and buildings.

3. Promotion of Mental Health and Social Wellbeing

Accessible local meeting spaces play an important role in promoting social cohesion and preventative wellbeing. The proposed facility will provide a welcoming and inclusive environment that supports regular social interaction, particularly benefiting:

- Elderly residents
- New parents
- Young people

Through structured activities, support groups, and community gatherings, the development will contribute positively to mental wellbeing and help reduce social isolation. These preventative benefits support wider public health objectives and enhance community resilience.

4. Women-Focused Community Provision

Locally accessible, culturally sensitive provision for women's health, wellbeing, and community engagement is limited. The proposed development will provide appropriate and inclusive space for programmes supporting women's participation, learning, and wellbeing. This will promote equality of access to community facilities and address the needs of under-served groups within the borough.

5. Provision of Safe and Structured Youth Space

The development will provide a supervised environment for youth activities that supports positive engagement and personal development. Structured youth provision is widely recognised as contributing to community safety, social development, and educational support. By offering a managed venue for young people, the proposal will provide a constructive alternative to unsupervised gathering in public spaces.

6. Accessible Faith and Community Infrastructure

The proposal will deliver a purpose-designed, properly managed facility that integrates faith use with wider community functions. This approach will reduce reliance on informal or temporary arrangements and provide improved accessibility, safety, and organisation of community activities. The development will function as a shared civic resource that serves both faith-based and wider community needs.

Planning Balance and Response to Potential Impacts

The proposal has been designed to ensure that any potential impacts are proportionate, appropriately managed, and outweighed by the significant public benefits delivered.

The use will operate as a managed community facility with structured hours of operation and clear oversight, ensuring orderly use and minimising disturbance. Activity patterns associated with places of worship and community facilities are typically time-specific and predictable, allowing effective management of arrivals, departures, and site use.

In relation to traffic and parking, community and faith-based uses generally generate dispersed and time-limited movements, often outside peak commuter periods. The site's local accessibility encourages walking, shared travel, and public transport use. Where necessary, operational management measures can be implemented to support responsible parking behaviour and minimise impacts on neighbouring amenity.

Noise and general amenity impacts are expected to be limited due to the indoor nature of the primary activities and the managed character of the facility. The proposal replaces informal or temporary arrangements with a properly designed and regulated environment, improving oversight and reducing the likelihood of unmanaged gatherings.

When assessed in the round, the development delivers substantial and enduring community benefits, including accessible social infrastructure, improved wellbeing provision, inclusive community participation, and enhanced local cohesion. These public benefits strongly align with the social and community objectives of the London Borough of Sutton and materially outweigh any limited and manageable impacts associated with the use.

Conclusion

The proposed development delivers clear and demonstrable public benefit through the provision of accessible social infrastructure. It will support community cohesion, promote health and wellbeing, provide affordable space for local activities, and respond directly to identified gaps in community provision.

For these reasons, the proposal represents a sustainable and policy-aligned form of development that will make a positive contribution to the borough and its residents.